

A forward camp of the Indian Army on the Siachen Glacier, July 1991. (ANNIRUDHA MOOKERJEE/AFP FILES/AFP via Getty Images)

In 1983, Pakistan asked India to withdraw its troops beyond the LC between NJ 9842 and the Karakoram Pass. To pre-empt any Pakistani move to occupy the area, the Indian Army launched Operation *Meghdoot* to secure the Siachen, Lolofond and Teram Shehr glaciers and the Bilafond La and Sia La passes. The operation began in March 1984 when a battalion of the Kumaon Regiment and the Ladakh Scouts marched through a snowbound Zojila Pass for days to avoid detection. The first sub-unit established a position on the heights of the Siachen Glacier while the next secured Bilafond La; the other sub-units secured the remaining heights of the Saltoro Ridge. By 13 April, approximately 300 Indian troops were dug in on the glacier.

The operation resulted in India gaining the Siachen Glacier and all its tributary glaciers, as well as the Sia La, Bilafond La and Gyong La passes. In 1987, Pakistan tried to capture the ridge and passes in an assault led by (then) Brigadier Pervez Musharraf, which captured a few high points before being pushed back. In Operation *Rajiv* (23–26 June 1987), the Indian Army's Naib Subedar Bana Singh led his team in a daring daylight attack, climbing over 460m of ice cliff to capture a major Pakistani post, the Quaid,